

Microsoft Bot Framework: According to one study, 41 per cent of businesses prefer the Microsoft Bot Framework. It has its own Bot Builder SDK that includes the SDK for .NET and Node.js. The entire system consists of three parts – the bot connector, the developer portal and the bot directory. This framework is open source, available to all on GitHub, and supports automatic translation to more than 30 languages. It incorporates LUIS (Language Understanding Intelligent Service) for natural language understanding, Cortana for voice and Bing APIs for search.

Dialog Flow: This is a mature chatbot-creation platform, perfectly suited to build intent-based chatbots. It was previously known as Api.ai. It currently has SDKs for Android, iOS, Cordova, Unity, Xamarin, HTML, JavaScript, Node.js, Epson Moverio, C++, Python, Ruby, PHP, Java, etc. A total of 14 languages are supported. It also comes with training modules.

Amazon Lex: This is the background technology used in the NLP/NLU engine for Amazon Alexa.

Many Chat: Many Chat lets you create a Facebook Messenger bot for marketing, sales and support. It's easy to use and free.

Semantic Machines: The features of this platform include a conversation engine, speech synthesis, deep learning, reinforcement learning, speech recognition, semantic intent extraction and natural learning generation (NLG) technology. It goes beyond just understanding conversations. This platform is language-independent.

Chat Fuel: More than 360,000 chatbots have been created using Chat Fuel, serving more than 17 million users globally. Many plugins for it have been developed. Some of them are: Google Search, Bing Search, JSON API, RSS import, subscribe plugin, Digest, Zapier, user input, live chat, etc. Chat Fuel supports about 50 languages and is free.

Chatter Bot: This is a Python library that makes it possible to generate responses based on a collection of known conversations. The Chatter bot language is independent.

Keeping service in mind

Have you ever used a customer support live chat service? You may at that time have got the impression that you are chatting with a person rather than a robot.

Whether you love chatbots or hate them, they are here to stay. They are becoming extremely popular in today's Web context due to the dramatic advances in machine learning, natural language processing, etc. Today's chatbots are friendlier, smarter, more responsive and more informative. And we may see even more features added in the coming years. Today one can make one's own chatbot that can be used on Facebook Messenger.

Briefly described below are some companies that use chatbots to provide better customer service.

Casper - Helping sleep disorders: Are you facing sleepless nights? Are you feeling lonely? Enter Casper's Insomnobot 3000, a conversational agent that offers relief to insomniacs.

Disney - A chatbot to solve crimes with fictional characters: Popular characters from animation movies are now becoming chatbots. Disney has launched one of its characters from the hit 'Zootopia' as a chatbot on Facebook Messenger. The conversational agent is Lieutenant Judy Hopps, the much admired rabbit from the movie.

Med What - Makes medical diagnosis faster: If you are bored with medical websites or self-diagnosing yourself with life-threatening diseases, the Med What chatbot is of help. It makes medical diagnosis faster, easier and more transparent for both patients and doctors.

Roof Ai - Generating and assigning leads automatically: Are you a marketing executive? Then you may know the importance of route assignment. Roof Ai may help real estate marketers to find potential customers for their houses and apartments. The bot identifies potential leads via Facebook and responds almost instantaneously in friendly, helpful and conversational tones that closely resemble that of a real person.

Types of chatbots

Chatbots are available in all shapes and sizes with varying capabilities. Basic chatbots are enough for most of the use cases. For some requirements, advanced chatbots may be required.

There are basically three types of chatbots, as listed below.

Menu/button based chatbots: These are the most basic type of chatbots available today. They usually come with decision tree hierarchies presented in the form of buttons. Similar to the automated phone menus, these chatbots require the user to make several selections to dig deeper towards the ultimate answer.

Keyword recognition based chatbots: These chatbots can attend to what the user types and respond appropriately, or at least try to. These chatbots use customisable keywords and AI to give solutions to customers' problems.

Today, a hybrid of key word recognition based and menu/ button based chatbots are also available in the market. This sophisticated technology, which is based on the principles of AI and data mining, can detect and interpret the problems of customers pretty accurately.

Contextual chatbots: These are far more advanced, incorporating both machine learning (ML) and artificial intelligence (AI). They remember conversations with specific users, and learn and become smarter with time. These bots come with self-improvement characteristics.